

Metaphor Changes Policy Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 25-30 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	25-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	metaphor-changes-policy

Big idea: Metaphors guide reasoning.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students test whether metaphors guide reasoning.

Student Prompt

Inspect Metaphor Changes Policy Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Metaphor Changes Policy Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Crime described as a beast, virus, puzzle, business, or symptom. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Metaphor Changes Policy Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Policy options that feel natural under each metaphor. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Metaphor Changes Policy Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A discussion on how metaphors smuggle in causes and solutions. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Metaphors guide reasoning.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Metaphor Changes Policy Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Metaphor Changes Policy Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Do metaphors reveal truth or create interpretations?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Language.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how metaphors guide reasoning.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: Do metaphors reveal truth or create interpretations?

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: Crime described as a beast, virus, puzzle, business, or symptom.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- Crime described as a beast, virus, puzzle, business, or symptom.
- Policy options that feel natural under each metaphor.
- A discussion on how metaphors smuggle in causes and solutions.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/metaphor-changes-policy/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/metaphor-changes-policy/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/metaphor-changes-policy/visual-prompt.svg>
- Printable student worksheet with observation, inference, evidence, and confidence columns.
- Teacher notes with setup checklist, sample facilitation language, misconceptions, and assessment look-fors.
- Classroom run kit with prompt cards, example stimuli, and debrief moves.
- PowerPoint deck with a student-facing sequence for running the activity.

Run Sequence

1. Give half the class Version A and half Version B.
2. Groups propose three policies.
3. Compare whether solutions are more preventive, diagnostic, punitive or forceful.
4. Reveal that only the metaphor changed.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: Do metaphors reveal truth or create interpretations?

- Are some metaphors more ethical than others?
- How do metaphors shape public policy and science communication?

Teacher Quick Script

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...